Challenging Your Thoughts

Cognitive distortion is a thought pattern that can lead to negative emotions and behaviors. If you notice that your mood is shifting or you find yourself falling into patterns that aren't helpful, review the list of cognitive distortions and reflect on the questions. See if you can identify and challenge any cognitive distortions that may be impacting your mood.

Common cognitive distortions

Overgeneralization: Thinking that one bad thing will always be bad.
All-or-nothing thinking: Believing things are either all good or all bad, with no middle ground.
Emotional reasoning: Thinking something is true just because you feel it strongly.
Personalization: Blaming yourself for things that aren't really your fault.
Filtering: Only paying attention to the bad stuff and ignoring the good.
"Should" statements: Telling yourself you must do things a certain way, even if it's not fair or realistic.
Catastrophizing: Imagining the worst possible outcome, even if it's unlikely.
Labeling: Using mean or negative words to describe yourself or others.
Jumping to conclusions: Making guesses about what people think or what will happen without proof.
Magnification and minimization: Making bad things seem bigger than they are or good things seem smaller.
Discounting the positive: Saying good things don't count or aren't important.

Questions to ask yourself if you are experiencing cognitive distortions:

1. What happened that made you feel a cognitive distortion? ***Try to describe the situation clearly.***
2. Name the cognitive distortion that you are experiencing.
3. What am I thinking right now? ***Write down the thoughts going through your head.***
4. Are my thoughts based on facts or feelings? ***Is there proof, or am I just feeling this way?***
5. Am I only looking at the bad side of things? ***Did I forget to notice anything good?***
6. Am I thinking in "all or nothing" terms? ***Do I think things are either perfect or terrible?***
7. Am I blaming myself for something I didn't cause? ***Is it really my fault?***
8. Am I guessing what others think or what will happen next? ***Do I really know, or am I just guessing?***
9. Am I using words like "always," "never," or "should"? ***Are these words making me feel worse?***
10. Am I making a small problem feel huge? ***Is it really that big of a deal?***
11. Am I calling myself or someone else a mean name? ***Is that fair or kind?***
12. Have I forgotten about the good things I've done or that happened? ***Can I name something positive?***